

benchmarkai

What building a competitive intelligence tool taught me about AI strategy

When it comes to AI Integration, the failure mode is not ambition but rather information asymmetry. AI investment is at record levels, yet companies are struggling to realize business impact. Everyone is asking the same question: *what are my competitors doing?* 51% of executives say strategy is the biggest driver of AI ROI. However, only 22% of operations leaders report a fully developed AI strategy. (Grant Thornton, 2026) Given the complexities of integrating AI systems, firms need to look internally to understand how agents, teams, and workflows fit within their unique business context. Yet AI adoption is largely driven by competitive instinct rather than internal strategy; despite record investment in AI integration, 95% of pilot projects fail to realize measurable business impact. (Challapally et al., 2025)

Strategic intelligence is about sorting through signals from the market to identify what is actionable and what is just noise. As AI transforms workflows, firms must balance competitive intelligence with strategic integration to realize business impact. Organizations are making \$30–40 billion in AI investment decisions without structured intelligence on how competitors are deploying. (Challapally et al., 2025) I built *benchmarkai* to test whether that gap was closeable.

I am an MBA Candidate at IMD Business school, with 6 years of experience scaling technical operations in the sports industry. Systems thinking is at the core of how I approach strategy: a habit built across industries and sharpened further when I flew to Singapore for a one-month technical immersion program. After just one week it became clear that AI literacy is becoming critical for businesses to maintain a competitive advantage. Internal capability paired with strategic intelligence will drive organizational resilience as firms navigate the constant reality of geopolitical turbulence.

Concept

I built *benchmarkai* to test my ability to conceptualize, design, and build an AI tool. The goal was to provide quick reports with high-level insights regarding AI integration and impact. I structured the output to augment human judgement, not replace it. Visual aids, a clearly defined methodology, and accessible references create the foundation for interpretation and transparency. Each report scores firms on explicit behavioral data, cites every source, and flags where evidence is weak.

Benchmarkai evaluates larger, digitally visible corporations against three criteria:

1. **Agentic Integration**
2. **Workforce Transformation**
3. **Quantified Business Impact**

These pillars are interpreted based on *The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025* report to understand how firms can deliver value, not just noise. (Challapally, 2025) The final report is directionless on its own: human judgement turns output into actionable intelligence.

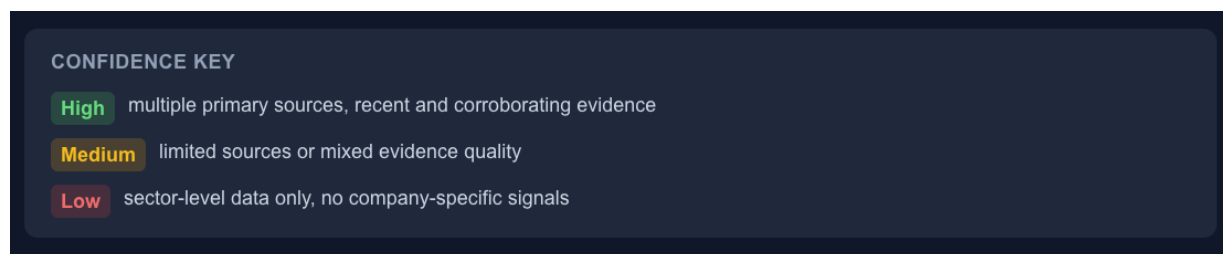
Design

Benchmarkai reports are built on three layers of intelligence: benchmarking, live signals, and human judgement. The first layer uses reports from McKinsey and Co., IMD Business School, Stanford University, and OECD to frame the competitors and direct the live signaling. This is the only continuous layer across all reports. The second layer pulls public data from the web for live signaling on firm-specific activity. The third layer employs the user as an active catalyst for synthesizing reported insights into actionable intelligence. A two-minute run time, repeatable methodology, and organized framework make it possible to quickly check the pulse on every business grappling with AI impact.

Build

The first key to *benchmarkai* is transparent methodology.

In a time when noise can be mistaken for signals, high-integrity data is key to building user trust. Reports like the EY Parthenon *Points of Attack*—retracted after 60% of references were found to be hallucinated—are calling into question the integrity of AI content. (Foley, 2026) While AI is a powerful tool for synthesizing data, clear framing and academically standardized references are essential for trustworthy reporting.



The confidence key ranks every insight and a full reference list is included.

A one-off report for a competitor firm is useless—a repeatable pulse-check of activity is strategically necessary. 94 frontier models were produced in the US and China in 2025, driving record organizational impact. (Maslej et al., 2026) Strategists need replicable intelligence that includes the most recent signals without losing sight of the foundational context. *Benchmarkai* explores the relationship between timely insights and trustworthy information.

The second key to *benchmarkai* is the design.

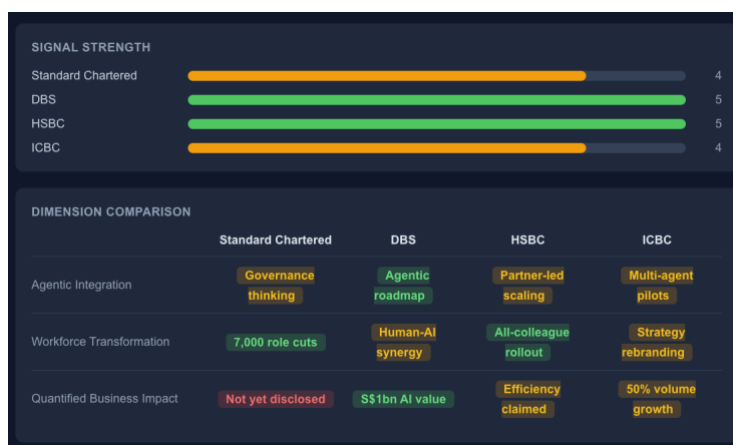
The tool provides clarity by delivering a report that requires user interpretation. Visualizations, standardized sections, and future facing recommendations preserve nuance; comprehensive reference methodology invites scrutiny. Insights are organized from abstract to specific with the confidence key creating an unavoidable visual thread that ties the report together.



The Strategic Positioning and Competitive Radar use insights from the report to position each in relation to each other. These visualizations are essential for inviting abstraction, prompting inquiry, and establishing a cadence of critical thinking.

The third key to *benchmarkai* is critical analysis.

Qualitative visualizations and confidence level assessments deliberately invite criticism. While some reference may be strongly supported by multiple primary sources, low level insights are also included when the live signal search derives insights from unverified sources. The blended reporting is paired with critical analysis to invite human judgement as the key mechanism for securing conclusive insights. Every report is an executive level summary of the loudest public signals. Every conclusion is the critical analysis of the user. This critical layer intentionally highlights the necessity of collaboration between AI reporting and human judgement.



The Signal Strength and Dimension Comparison immediately highlight credibility gaps in every report.

Key Learnings

AI is an unprecedented tool for innovation, but human judgement remains the key ingredient in building something real. Programs like *Claude* make coding more accessible than ever because they allow developers to communicate using natural language and the LLM translates intent into output. Although *Claude* can quickly write code, the output risks misalignment with user intent.

Yet at the heart of all AI coding is the fact that LLMs are probabilistic in all outputs, not deterministic. This is why coding outputs risk significant deviation from user inputs. As a human-AI

team, alignment and trust are critical enablers of strong execution. This core question informed my design choices when building *benchmarkai*:

How can AI build effective tools when relying on probabilistic outputs?

It took me five hours to draft *benchmarkai*; it took me all weekend to build structurally sound architecture. Prompting the output was fast but refining the methodology was tedious. Although *Claude* built me an MVP in minutes, the underlying architecture was buggy and inconsistent at executing tasks. A core challenge when coding with *Claude* is that AI accumulates bias: after the first output, subsequent code is layered over existing architecture. Prompting *Claude* to re-evaluate the foundational layers of the tool was a battle against this bias. I have three key takeaways:

- 1. AI can build quickly, but not always efficiently.**

When a user prompts AI in natural language, the computer infers output. The primary risk is misinterpreting the output. The degree to which the AI output is accurate directly correlates to the efficiency of the process: the less precise the output the less efficient the process.

- 2. AI cannot infer user intent.**

AI tools are only as robust as the critical thinking behind them. The sequence and series of prompts balance creative potential with a determined output. A prompt defines the parameters, the LLM defines the output.

- 3. AI tools are never finished.**

An AI tool is inherently limited to the operating model used in the build. New models are constantly in development, enabling new thinking processes. Updating, testing, and iterating an AI build remain necessary decisions in the lifetime of a project.

The Payoff

I asked over a dozen companies in Singapore how AI was transforming their firm. From government supported startups to huge multinational firms like JLL, everyone is integrating AI workflows. Yet I was surprised by the lack of strategic depth in these organizations given that 90% of individuals are reportedly using personal AI tools. (Challapally et al., 2025) Thus, while individual productivity is being measurably impacted—activity that has disproportionate impact in small organizations like startups—large corporate P&Ls are not reflecting this value creation. (Challapally et al., 2025)

The firms with the loudest signals do not necessarily demonstrate the most substantial AI integration. *Benchmarkai* highlights this information asymmetry in the example report on Spotify, Apple Music, and Amazon Music. Apple announced significant AI spending, yet the company scores low confidence and has no disclosed AI features comparable to Spotify's AI DJ. Amazon Music's Maestro is still in beta with no quantified impact reported. A company could benchmark itself against Apple Music and conclude they are behind on AI, when the truth is Apple Music simply has not disclosed business impact. This reveals the distinction between signal volume and intelligence quality.

A pattern emerged across the reports I ran, clustering firms into three groups: those still experimenting in isolated functions, those that have achieved strategic depth in specific processes but stopped there, and the rare few that are continuously iterating.

I hypothesize that most firms stop at stage one or two because they lack the intelligence infrastructure to strategize for the next stage. Organizations that fully integrate AI beyond the pilot stage are 4x more likely to report revenue growth (58% versus 15%). (Grant Thornton, 2026) Most firms stop at experimentation and never realize strategic depth of implementation. *The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025* report by MIT states that projects delivering value can be identified by three key characteristics: deep integration into specific processes, continuous learning capability and evaluation based on business outcomes. (Challapally, 2025) 73% of business with measurable impact reported that ROI fell short of their expectations. (G-P, 2026) A further 16% of businesses reported negative returns on AI investment.

Strategic Implications

Benchmarkai works because the signals are loud; but signaling is not a proxy for business impact. As firms update workflows at an unprecedented rate, just 20% of firms are benefitting. With 70% of executives prepared to scale back AI integration if returns are not met, the window for course correction is narrowing. (G-P, 2026) Organizations that succeed at holding tension between experimentation and strategic depth of implementation will be in the winning group.

When it comes to AI Integration, every business is asking the same question: what are my competitors doing?

This is the wrong question. Instead, we need to ask:

What stage of integration have we reached, what does the next stage require, and how do we mobilize the organization?

That is the question *benchmarkai* was built to answer: not where your competitors stand, but where you do.

[Run a report.](#)

Notes

- [1] Arjun Challapally, Caleb Pease, Ramesh Raskar, and Praneeth Chari, [*The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025*](#) (MIT NANDA, July 2025).
- [2] Grant Thornton, [*2026 AI Impact Survey Report*](#) (Grant Thornton Advisors LLC, April 2026).
- [3] McKinsey & Company, [*The State of AI in 2025: Agents, Innovation, and Transformation*](#) (McKinsey & Company, November 2025).
- [4] PwC, [*2026 AI Performance Study*](#) (PwC, April 2026).
- [5] Antonia Clemente, [*AI Adoption Remains High, Yet Value May Lag Without Modernization and Workflow Integration*](#) (Harvard Business Review Analytic Services, April 2026).
- [6] G-P, [*AI at Work: The 2026 Reality Check*](#) (Globalization Partners, May 2026).
- [7] Nils Maslej et al., [*The 2026 AI Index Report*](#) (Stanford University Human-Centered AI, April 2026).
- [8] Precedence Research, [*Artificial Intelligence Market Size, Share & Trends 2025 to 2034*](#) (Precedence Research, June 2025).
- [9] PitchBook, [*Q4 2025 Global VC First Look*](#) (PitchBook Data, February 2026).
- [10] Stephen Foley, [*EY retracts study after researchers discover AI hallucinations*](#) (Financial Times, 2026).
- [11] MacKenzie Sigalos and Jennifer Elias, [*Apple's R&D Spending Climbs to 10% of Revenue on AI Investments*](#) (CNBC, May 6, 2026).

Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic, 2026) was used throughout the drafting process as an editorial partner: providing structural feedback, evaluating argument cohesion, conducting source validation, and suggesting line-level revisions. All analytical claims, strategic interpretations, and conclusions are the author's own. benchmarkai was built using Claude Code. AI. Assisted editing does not imply AI authorship.